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Deciding to believe again

Keith Frankish

Abstract: This paper defends direct activism — the view that it is possible to form beliefs in a causally direct way. In particular, it addresses the charge that direct activism entails voluntarism — the thesis that we can form beliefs at will. It distinguishes weak and strong varieties of voluntarism and argues that, although direct activism may entail the weak variety, it does not entail the strong one. The paper goes on to argue that strong voluntarism is non-contingently false, sketching a new argument for that conclusion. This argument does not tell against the weak form of voluntarism, however, and the final part of the paper argues that weak voluntarism, and consequently direct activism, remains a coherent and defensible position.

1. Introduction

It is widely accepted that the extent of our control over our own beliefs is, at best, limited. Although acknowledging that we can do things that will indirectly lead to our acquiring a desired belief, most writers deny that we can form beliefs *directly*, in a causally unmediated way, simply by forming and executing an intention to do so. That is, they hold that we cannot simply *decide to believe*. I want to reopen this issue. The view that we can form beliefs directly — *direct activism*, as I shall call it — has, I believe, been written off too hastily.

There are two reasons for being suspicious of direct activism. One is that belief does not seem to be the sort of state that can be actively created and sustained. It seems, rather, to be a dispositional state, which is passively formed and cannot be altered by a simple act of will. Now I have argued elsewhere that this is not a decisive objection to direct activism. The concept of belief is a multi-faceted one, and although there are some kinds of belief that are not open to active control, there is another sort which may be (Frankish 1998, 2004). I shall say a little more about this later, but it will not be the main focus of this paper. Instead, I want to examine the second reason for rejecting direct activism. This is that the thesis is assumed to entail a stronger claim, to the effect that we can believe *at will*. The thought is that if we could form beliefs directly, then we could form them for purely pragmatic reasons, regardless of their truth or probability. So, for example, if it would help my job prospects to believe that my boss's jokes are funny, then I would be able to form that belief, just like that, regardless of whether or not I had any evidence for its truth. And this claim — *voluntarism*, as it is often known — is

implausible.[1] I certainly do not find myself able to form beliefs in that way. Indeed, it has been argued that voluntarism is *necessarily* false — that it is not just a contingent fact that we cannot believe at will, as it is a contingent fact that we cannot blush at will (Williams 1970). If this is right, and if direct activism entails voluntarism, then direct activism must be necessarily false, too.

This paper combines a defence of direct activism with a limited attack on voluntarism. I distinguish two varieties of voluntarism, which I call *weak* and *strong*. Strong voluntarism, I argue, is indeed non-contingently false. But weak voluntarism is defensible; few of the existing arguments touch it at all, and those that do can be defused. I argue, moreover, that direct activism entails, at most, only weak voluntarism and thus that one can defend direct activism without incurring a commitment to an objectionable form of voluntarism. (No positive arguments for the truth of direct activism will be offered, however; the aim is merely to show that there are no a priori arguments for its falsity.)

There are three stages to the strategy. I shall first define the theses to be defended and rejected, then outline a new argument against strong voluntarism, and finally defend the coherence of weak voluntarism. The positive and negative objectives of the paper are closely connected; in constructing a case against the strong form of voluntarism we shall see how to defend the weak form. The discussion will also reveal something about what kind of act an act of direct belief formation would have to be.

2. Direct activism and voluntarism

I want to defend the possibility of direct active belief formation. More precisely, I want to argue that there are no a priori reasons for rejecting the following thesis:

> *Direct activism*. It is possible to form a belief with content *p* simply by performing a one-off action — call it 'endorsement' — in relation to the content *p*, where this action:
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> (i) can be performed deliberately and in full consciousness,
>
> (ii) can be the object of practical reasoning,
>
> (iii) is causally basic, and
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> (iv) is intentional under the description *forming the belief that p* (or some equivalent).

[1] The term 'voluntarism' is also used for a normative thesis to the effect that it is sometimes rational to form beliefs at will. I shall have nothing to say about this normative thesis here.

I shall refer to this as the thesis that we can form beliefs *directly*.

A few comments on the definition. First, endorsement is an act of belief *formation*, not of *believing*. The claim is not that believing itself can be an action, but that belief formation can be. Secondly, in characterizing endorsement as a *causally basic* action, I mean that it is one that can be performed directly and without first performing some other action that causes it. So in this respect endorsement is like raising one's arm and unlike, say, getting drunk. It is this clause that distinguishes direct activism from the thesis that we can actively form beliefs by indirect means. Thirdly, the force of the last clause is that the act of endorsing a content can be motivated by reflection on the desirability of having a belief with that content; the act can be the object of genuine practical reasoning under that description. This distinguishes the version of direct activism defended here from a weaker version defended by Philip Pettit (Pettit 1993, chapter two). Fourthly, direct activism is a weak, permissive thesis; it says that it is *possible* to form beliefs directly, not that this is the only or usual way to form them. Thus it is compatible with direct activism that there are types of belief (perceptual ones, for example) that can only be formed passively. Finally, note that I am using 'endorsement' as a technical term, whose meaning is fixed by the definition above. In everyday speech the word may have connotations that it does not have here.

I turn now to voluntarism — the view that we can form beliefs at will. This is typically glossed as the tripartite thesis that it is possible to form beliefs (1) in a causally direct way, (2) in full consciousness, and (3) irrespective of truth considerations (Pojman 1985; Williams 1970; Winters 1979). Claims (1) and (2) are included in our definition of direct activism, so we can think of voluntarism as direct activism with the rider that contents can be endorsed irrespective of truth considerations. The doctrine is rarely defined with more precision than this. Yet there are two aspects to the claim about truth considerations, which need to be distinguished.

First, there is a claim about *motivation*, to the effect that acts of endorsement can be performed for pragmatic reasons as well as for epistemic ones. By 'epistemic reasons' I mean concerns for truth, and I shall say that an act of endorsement is epistemically motivated if its goal is to acquire a true belief on the topic in question. (Thus, the motivating belief in such cases will be one to the effect that the content to be endorsed is well-warranted, or something similar.) By 'pragmatic reasons' I mean reasons that are not epistemic in this sense, and I shall say that an act of endorsement is pragmatically motivated if its goal is to promote some

end other than the possession of a true belief on the topic in question. Of course, the desire to have a true belief on some topic may itself be the product of practical concerns, such as a desire to make money, but on the present view that does not alter its status as epistemic.[2] Secondly, there is a claim about the *extent* of our powers of endorsement, to the effect that we can endorse any content we like, regardless of whether or not we have any reason to think it true. I shall say that such reasons constitute *epistemic support* for the content, and I shall say that a person *has* epistemic support for a content if they know of some such reason. I shall assume that epistemic support may take a variety of forms — empirical evidence, self-evidence, testimony, coherence with other beliefs, and so on. Thus, we can distinguish two versions of the claim that we can endorse contents irrespective of truth considerations:

> (a) Acts of endorsement can be pragmatically motivated.
>
> (b) Acts of endorsement can be performed upon contents for which the agent has no epistemic support.[3]

I shall assume that the 'in full consciousness' clause in the definition of endorsement carries over to (a) and (b). So, for example, (b) is the claim that we can endorse contents for which we lack epistemic support and in full consciousness that we lack such support.

Now, corresponding to these two claims, we have two versions of voluntarism: one obtained by supplementing direct activism with (a), the other by supplementing it with (b) as well. (I shall assume that (b) implies (a); a person who knowingly endorses a content that they have no reason to think true, cannot — unless they are very confused or the circumstances very odd — be doing so for epistemic reasons.) I shall refer to these theses as *weak voluntarism* and *strong voluntarism* respectively, and I shall use the expression 'at will' in connection with the second thesis only. To sum up:

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[2] Similarly, the desire to possess a false belief on some topic might be the product of wider concerns with truth. For example, I might want to believe that my partner is faithful, despite the evidence to the contrary, since without such a belief I would be unable to continue with my academic inquiries. Again, this does not alter the pragmatic status of the desire, since it is not directed at the truth of the particular belief in question.

[3] The two versions reflect an ambiguity in the phrase 'at will'. Sometimes we use the phrase simply to indicate that an action can be performed intentionally. So we can raise our arms at will but cannot blush at will. But we also use the phrase to mark a stronger claim, to the effect that an action can be performed *whenever* one wishes. For example, we might praise a person for being able to say witty things at will.

> The *direct activist* claims that we can form beliefs directly.
>
> The *weak voluntarist* claims that we can form beliefs directly and for pragmatic reasons.
>
> The *strong voluntarist* claims that we can form beliefs directly, for pragmatic reasons, and without epistemic support ('at will').

Weak and strong voluntarism are rarely distinguished either from each other or from direct activism, perhaps because it has been assumed that they stand or fall together. If we could form beliefs directly, then, it seems, we could form them for pragmatic reasons, and if our pragmatic reasons for having a certain belief were strong enough, then we could form it even if we had no reason to think it true. Is this correct? There is at least a prima facie case for thinking that direct activism entails weak voluntarism. If endorsement can be the object of practical reasoning, then how could it be responsive to some reasons and not others? But direct activism does not entail strong voluntarism. I might have an ability, and be able to exercise it for whatever reasons I want, yet be unable to exercise it on whatever *occasion* I want. There might be enabling conditions for its exercise. Moreover, the enabling conditions for an action might be *doxastic* — involving the possession, or lack, of certain beliefs. Consider promising. We can make promises for any reason we please, but there are restrictions on *what* we can promise. We cannot seriously promise to do something that we believe ourselves incapable of doing (though we can, of course, *say* that we promise to do it). Believing that one is able to *A* is an enabling condition — and a non-contingent one at that — for promising to *A*. And something similar might be true of belief formation. Having reasons for thinking *p* true might be an enabling condition for the act of endorsing *p*. That is, it is possible that one might be *motivated* to endorse a content for which one has no epistemic support, but unable to *perform* the act unless one possesses such support. If this is right, then the strong version of voluntarism is not entailed by the weaker one, and it is possible to embrace one but not the other. I think this is good news for direct activists. For it is strong voluntarism that is the objectionable thesis; there is, I shall argue, no a priori reason for rejecting the weak version. So even if direct activism entails weak voluntarism, this is not a reason to reject the doctrine.

The possibility of adopting an intermediate position which concedes weak voluntarism but rejects strong has been generally ignored, perhaps because the two forms of voluntarism have not been distinguished. Those sympathetic to direct activism typically regard themselves as committed to arguing that acts of direct belief formation can be performed only for epistemic reasons (Walker 1996, 2001;

for related positions, see Montmarquet 1986; Shah 2002). That is, they hold that reasons to think a proposition true are not only required for the success of an act of endorsement, but must also play a role in its motivation. Such a view may be defensible, but I think the intermediate position is worth exploring, and it harmonizes well with a certain view of belief which I shall sketch later. Of course, more needs to be said in defence of the coherence of weak voluntarism. How *could* possession of epistemic support be an enabling condition for an act of belief formation? What would there be to stop us from endorsing contents for which we had no epistemic support, if our pragmatic reasons for believing them were strong enough? First, however, I want to focus on strong voluntarism. In coming to see what is wrong with that thesis we shall put ourselves in a better position to defend the coherence of its weaker cousin.

3. Strong voluntarism

As I mentioned, there is a widespread sense that strong voluntarism is non-contingently false — that there is something in the nature of belief that makes it impossible to decide to believe a proposition for which one lacks epistemic support. Despite numerous attempts, however, it has proved hard to articulate a sound argument for this conclusion. I shall not rehearse the arguments and criticisms here, though some points will emerge in what follows. Instead, I shall aim to construct a better version, drawing on the lessons of earlier attempts.[4]

I shall assume that any argument against strong voluntarism must meet two constraints. First, it should not rule out the possibility of passively acquiring beliefs for which we lack epistemic support. There are numerous non-rational processes that can give rise to belief, and we do not want to purchase a refutation of strong voluntarism at the cost of denying this.[5] The second constraint is that the argument should not rule out the possibility of actively forming unwarranted beliefs by indirect means, such as submitting oneself to indoctrination or practising

[4] For some earlier arguments against strong voluntarism, see Church 2002; Noordhof 2001; O'Shaughnessy 1980; Pears 1992; Pettit 1993; Pojman 1985, 1986; Scott-Kakures 1994; Swinburne 1981; Williams 1970.

[5] Some writers, it is true, have contemplated this option, suggesting that it is central to our concept of belief that belief states are the product of truth-directed evidential mechanisms (Williams 1970, pp. 148–9; see also Pears 1992, p. 363; Scott-Kakures 1994, pp. 84–5). But I see no reason to think that aetiological factors are decisive in this way. Certainly, we are happy to allow that *others* may possess beliefs that are the product of non-rational processes.

auto-suggestion. As I mentioned earlier, this possibility is widely conceded.[6] The most promising strategy for meeting these constraints is, I believe, what Dion Scott-Kakures has dubbed the *self-defeatingness gambit* (Scott-Kakures 1994). This turns on the idea that we could not seriously regard one of our own mental states as a belief if we knew that it had been formed without regard for its truth. Thus, although we could unwittingly acquire a belief for which we had no epistemic support, we could not consciously decide to acquire one, since we would not be able to regard the resulting state as a belief. The act would be self-defeating.

The best-known version of this gambit is one sketched by Bernard Williams (Williams 1970). To believe something, Williams points out, is to believe it *true* — to regard it as faithfully representing reality. And how could one think of a state as having this function if one knew that it had been formed without regard to its truth?

> If in full consciousness I could will to acquire a 'belief' irrespective of its truth, it is unclear that before the event I could seriously think of it as a belief, i.e. as something purporting to represent reality. (Williams 1970, p. 148)

At the very least, Williams adds, one could not *retrospectively* think of it in this way. That is, we cannot regard one of our mental states as a belief if we think that its formation was not regulated by epistemic considerations, and, consequently, cannot regard it as a belief if we think that it was formed at will. Or, slightly more precisely, for any proposition *p*, it is impossible to believe in full consciousness both that one believes that *p* and that one's belief that *p* was formed at will. (Note the scope of the quantifier. There seems to be no similar barrier to believing that some, unidentified, member of one's belief set was formed at will.) I shall call this *Williams's Principle* or WP for short. It follows from this principle, Williams argues, that it is impossible to form beliefs at will. If I could not think of any particular belief of mine as having been formed at will, then I could not believe myself *able* to form beliefs at will. But if one can perform a certain action, then one can recognize, or at least be brought to recognize, that one can perform it. Since it is impossible for me to recognize that I could form beliefs at will, it is impossible for me to have the ability to do so.

As several writers have noted, this argument is flawed. First, there is a problem with WP. For, as Barbara Winters notes, there would be no difficulty in thinking

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[6] For a particularly clear account of how a pragmatically motivated strategy of indirect belief formation could be implemented without self-deception, see Cook 1987.

of a belief as having been originally formed at will, provided one thought that one had, since forming it, gained evidence for its truth (Winters 1979). Secondly, as Jonathan Bennett points out, the inference from WP to the conclusion is not sound. One might know from the testimony of others that one could and did perform actions of a certain type, even though one was, for some reason, systematically unable to recall occasions on which one had done so (Bennett 1990). And thirdly, even if sound, the argument would tell equally against the possibility of actively forming unwarranted beliefs by indirect means, thus violating our second constraint. Williams's version of the argument fails, then. But I think the strategy is sound and that a more successful version of it can be constructed. There are two stages to this. First we need to revise WP to avoid Winters's objection, then we need to show that this revised principle entails the falsity of strong voluntarism — and that it does so without violating our second constraint.

How should we reformulate WP? Winters suggests that we replace the reference to formation with one to sustention (Winters 1979). The relevant principle, she argues, is that it is not possible to believe, in full consciousness, both that one believes that *p* and that one's belief that *p* is not currently sustained by any truth considerations. (Winters explains that 'sustained' is to be understood in a causal/explanatory sense, rather than an evidential one, and that by 'truth considerations' she means data relevant to *p*'s truth or falsity.) In defence of this principle Winters describes various cases in which a subject discovers that one of their beliefs is not sustained by truth considerations. In each case, she suggests, the discovery would compel the subject to disown the belief and either eradicate it or reclassify it as a prejudice or piece of wishful thinking. This principle is too strong, however. Facts about the sustention of a mental state are not decisive in determining whether or not it qualifies as a belief, any more than facts about its origins are. For example, I believe that my closest friends are honest. I have lots of evidence that they are. But I am not sure that this evidence is what *causally sustains* my belief; indeed I am completely ignorant of the causal processes sustaining it. For all I know, it might be sustained solely by a desire to think well of my friends. But in accepting this I am not accepting that my attitude to the proposition that my friends are honest might be something other than *belief*. On the contrary, I am sure it is belief.[7]

[7] Pojman defends a principle similar to Winters's on the grounds that, since we know our beliefs are not *made true* by our desires, we cannot think of them as *sustained* by them either. I do not see why this follows. See Pojman 1985, 1986.

This suggests that what matters is, not whether we think truth considerations play a causal role in sustaining a belief, but simply whether we are aware of any such considerations — whether we possess any epistemic support for the belief. I shall say that propositions for which we lack epistemic support are *unsupported*. So perhaps the principle we want is that it is impossible to believe, in full consciousness, both that one believes that *p* and that one's belief that *p* is unsupported. (The examples Winters cites in favour of her principle tell equally, if not more strongly, in favour of this one; in each case, the subject comes to believe, not only that the problematical belief is not causally sustained by evidence, but also that they do not *have* any evidence for it.) Nevertheless, the proposed principle is still too strong. For we can happily retain a belief long after we have forgotten the reasons for believing it. One is not rationally compelled to reopen an inquiry just because one cannot recall why one arrived at the conclusion one did (Harman 1986; Lycan 1988). Indeed, since beliefs are typically the product of truth-directed processes, the very fact that one has come to believe a proposition affords one some reason to think it true. It is not impossible, then, to acquiesce in the possession of an unsupported belief (unsupported, that is, by anything other than the fact of its own existence). This assumes, however, that the belief in question was originally formed by truth-directed processes; if we were to discover that it owed its existence to factors wholly unconnected with truth, then the case would be different.[8] Let us say that a belief is *deviant* if it is the causal product of a desire to believe it or of other influences unconnected with truth. Then perhaps the principle we want is that it is impossible to regard oneself as believing that *p* if one believes *both* that there is no reason to think *p* true (beyond the fact that one does believe it) *and* that *p*'s presence in one's belief set is due to factors unconnected with truth. That is, we can accept that a belief is deviant provided we do not think it is unsupported (as in the case of my belief about my friends' honesty), and we can accept that a belief is unsupported provided we do not think it is deviant (as in the type of case just described). But we cannot seriously accept that a belief is *both* unsupported and deviant.

A problem remains, however. Suppose I notice that I habitually avoid treading on the cracks in the pavement. And suppose for the sake of argument that I infer

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[8] It is important to distinguish the probative force conferred by *inclusion* in one's belief set from that conferred by *coherence* with other members of the set. A proposition might get into one's belief box by deviant means but subsequently earn its place there by cohering well with the existing occupants. In the latter case, the proposition would, of course, no longer be unsupported.

from this that I have a non-conscious belief that treading on the cracks is dangerous, even though I know of no reason to think that it is. Suppose, too, that my analyst persuades me that this belief owes its existence to some suppressed fear rather than to truth-relevant considerations. And finally suppose that I cannot eradicate the belief and continue to catch myself avoiding the cracks. Then I shall believe, in full consciousness, both that I believe that treading on the cracks is dangerous and that this belief is both unsupported and deviant.

This might suggest that we should reformulate WP as a principle about belief formation; we may *find ourselves* with a belief that is unsupported and deviant, but we cannot directly *form* one. Such a principle would be sound, I think, but of course we could not use it to argue against strong voluntarism, since it is essentially equivalent to that thesis. If we are to use the self-defeatingness strategy to argue against the possibility of strongly voluntary belief formation, then we need a principle about belief possession. In fact, it is not too difficult to repair WP as such a principle. The important thing to note about the counterexample just described is that the belief in question is a *non-conscious* one. It is one I ascribe to myself in a third-person way, on the basis of behavioural evidence, not one I would consciously avow and take as an explicit premise in my conscious reasoning. Moreover, even after I have become consciously aware of its presence, the belief will remain non-conscious in this sense. It will not figure as a premise in my conscious reasoning, though it may bias that reasoning in subtle ways and may continue to influence my unreflective behaviour. (Think of how a prejudice may stop you trusting someone, even though you would neither avow nor endorse it.) And I shall exclude non-conscious beliefs from the scope of this argument. I suspect that our intuitions about the necessary falsity of strong voluntarism derive specifically from features of conscious belief and that it is a contingent matter that we cannot form non-conscious beliefs at will. At any rate, I shall not argue otherwise.

The principle I propose, then, is the following, which I shall refer to as the Revised Williams's Principle (RWP):

> For any proposition *p*, it is impossible to believe in full consciousness both that one consciously believes that *p* and that one's belief that *p* is both unsupported and deviant.

(For simplicity's sake I shall henceforth take the restriction to conscious belief as read.) I shall say more in defence of this principle shortly. First, however, I want to show how it entails the falsity of strong voluntarism.

There is obviously a tension between RWP and strong voluntarism. To streamline the discussion I shall introduce one further piece of terminology. Let us say that the act of forming a mental state *M* with content *p* is *wanton* if the agent performs it in full consciousness that they lack any reason to think *p* true and that they are forming *M* for pragmatic reasons. Thus, the strong voluntarist claims that we can perform acts of wanton endorsement. Now, if we had just formed a mental state by way of a wanton act, then we would typically know that the resulting state was unsupported and deviant, and would, therefore, be unable to regard it as a belief. Attempts to form beliefs in this way would therefore be self-defeating; the beliefs so formed would be unable to survive reflection on their status. (I assume that if one consciously repudiates a belief, then one will cease to believe it. I shall say more later about why this is so.) Thus, in order to succeed in an act of wanton endorsement, it would be necessary, not only to form a mental state with the appropriate content and motivational role, but also either (1) to form the belief that one has epistemic support for this mental state, or (2) to forget that the state had been formed for pragmatic reasons.[9] Moreover, since endorsement is by definition a causally basic act, we would have to bring about one of these conditions immediately, in a causally basic way. Is that possible?

The answer is that it is not. Take condition (1). At first sight, it might seem that we could bring this about immediately. If we could form beliefs at will, then why could we not form the additional belief that we have reason to think the first belief true? The problem, of course, is that we would be aware that this belief, too, was unsupported and deviant, and would therefore need to form a third belief to the effect that we have reason to think *it* true, and so on. (I am not suggesting that every belief requires support from a distinct belief to the effect that one has epistemic support for it; the need would arise in this case simply because the original belief had been formed in a way that left us aware of its status as unsupported and deviant.) Thus, in order to endorse one content we would need to endorse an infinite number of additional contents of ever-increasing order. Even if this were possible (which it surely is not), it would remain true that we could not form a belief with content *p* simply by performing a one-off action *in relation to the content p* — contrary to strong voluntarism.

Nor can we immediately bring about condition (2) — forgetting that the desired belief had been formed for pragmatic reasons. It is a psychological datum that we

[9] Church (2002) also argues that satisfying (1) or (2) is a precondition for successful active belief formation, though she is concerned with the indirect, rather than the direct, variety.

cannot directly forget things — that is, in a way that is intentional and causally basic. This is not to say that we cannot directly abandon beliefs; I would argue that in certain circumstances we can. But we cannot directly erase memories, and if a memory is sufficiently strong (as it will be in the case we are considering here), we shall be unable to resist believing its content. (This is, of course, one reason why self-deception is so problematic, since it seems that self-deceivers will need to erase the memory of their own deception.) Why we cannot directly erase memories is itself a puzzling question, which would require independent consideration. I suspect, however, that it is not a contingent fact that we cannot. (One obvious problem is that it would threaten to introduce a regress, similar to that just described for belief. In forgetting that *p*, I would need to forget that I had forgotten that *p*, and that I had forgotten that I had forgotten that *p*, and so on.)

The upshot of this is that at least some of the conditions necessary for success in an act of wanton endorsement are not within our control. It might be objected that this is not incompatible with the possibility of wanton endorsement. For the conditions might occur fortuitously. Upon attempting an act of wanton endorsement, we might fortuitously come to believe that we had epistemic support for the belief so formed, or (slightly more plausibly) fortuitously forget that we had performed the act for pragmatic reasons. I concede this point, but it does not save strong voluntarism. For it remains true that we cannot seriously *intend* to perform an act of wanton endorsement. For intention formation presupposes control; one cannot intend to perform a certain action if one believes that, in normal conditions, one has no control over whether or not one would succeed in performing it. For example, one cannot intend to pick a red card from a pack presented face down. We might call this the *Control Principle*. The principle is intuitively plausible, and it is a corollary both of traditional doxastic theories of intention, which hold that having an intention to *A* involves (among other things) believing that one will *A*, and of more recent planning theories, according to which intending to *A* involves being committed to *A*-ing. In either case, it is hard to see how one could form the required attitudes if one thought that one had no control over whether or not one would succeed in *A*-ing. The principle does not, of course, rule out succeeding in something by chance. We can pick a red card from a pack — that is, perform an action that turns out to be the picking of a red card. But we cannot seriously *intend* to pick a red card, since we have no control over the colour of the card we pick. The most we can intend to do is to pick a card and hope that it will be red. And for the same reason we cannot intend to perform an act of wanton

endorsement, since, as we have seen, we cannot control the conditions necessary for success. The best we can do in this case is intend to perform some other action, which might fortuitously turn out to be an act of wanton endorsement. For example, we might decide for pragmatic reasons to *assume* that a certain epistemically unsupported proposition is true, then instantly forget why we had done this and end up believing the proposition. But we cannot seriously intend to endorse it. And if we cannot do that, then we do not have the ability to form beliefs at will. [10]

The only exceptions here, I think, are self-fulfilling beliefs — that is, beliefs that tend to make their contents true, such as the belief that one can make a dangerous leap or that one will not get to sleep. Since the very existence of such a belief is evidence for its truth, one could bring about the first condition simply by forming the belief in question, and RWP would be no obstacle to one's intending to form that belief. I concede that the present argument does not tell against the possibility of forming beliefs like this at will. Perhaps it is possible to do so; people do sometimes try to believe that they will succeed in a task as a way of improving their chances of doing so. At any rate, if it is not possible, then the explanation must lie elsewhere.

It is worth stressing that this argument assumes full consciousness. It does not show that it is impossible to endorse a content for pragmatic reasons and without epistemic support — only that it is impossible to do so in full consciousness that this is what one is doing. If one happens to believe, falsely, that one does have epistemic support for a proposition, then RWP presents no barrier to one's forming a belief in it for pragmatic reasons. This reflects the limits of the self-defeatingness strategy, which, in turn, reflects the first of the two constraints set out earlier — that an argument against strong voluntarism should not rule out the passive acquisition of beliefs by non-rational means. The strategy does not aim to show that a belief cannot be unsupported and deviant, merely that it cannot be regarded by its possessor as such. This is not a weakness in the argument, of course. The 'full consciousness' clause is built into the definition of strong voluntarism, and I do not wish to argue against forms of voluntarism that drop it.

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[10] Dion Scott-Kakures (1994) has also outlined an argument against strong voluntarism which turns on considerations relating to the intentions involved. He does not invoke the Control Principle, however, but argues that an intention to acquire an unsupported belief could not play its normal behaviour-guiding role.

This, then, is the argument against strong voluntarism. Note that it meets the two constraints set out earlier. It does not rule out the passive acquisition of unsupported and deviant beliefs, but only the conscious, active formation of them. Nor is it incompatible with the possibility of actively forming unsupported beliefs by indirect means. For we can exercise *indirect* control over conditions (1) and (2). Most relevantly, we can take steps to secure condition (1). We can adopt strategies that will lead us, not only to acquire the desired belief, but also to form the belief that this belief is justified. Thus, although we cannot intend to *endorse* an unsupported proposition, where endorsement is a causally basic act, we can intend to *get ourselves to believe* one by indirect means. Finally, note that on this view the falsity of strong voluntarism is not contingent but follows from more basic principles, namely RWP and the Control Principle. (It is true that the argument also appeals to facts about our control over memory, which may be contingent. But, given those facts, the falsity of strong voluntarism is not a *further* contingent fact.)

I want to conclude this section by saying something about the status of RWP, which, I shall argue, follows from a basic feature of conscious belief. This will also prepare the ground for some suggestions in the next section. The argument turns on a distinction between conscious beliefs and some closely related attitudes.[11] If one consciously believes a proposition, then one will be disposed to use it as a premise in one's conscious reasoning, practical and theoretical. But not all propositions one is disposed to use in this way count as objects of belief. For example, a lawyer may take it as a premise in their professional deliberations that their client is innocent, without actually believing that they are. We might say that the lawyer's attitude is one of *professional belief* or *acceptance* (Cohen 1992). Similarly, a scientist may take a hypothesis as a premise when designing experiments or analysing results, without really believing it. What distinguishes these belief-like attitudes (*quasi-beliefs*, we might say) from genuine beliefs? The crucial factor, I suggest, is context. We are guided by our hypotheses and professional beliefs only in certain special deliberative contexts — social, professional, academic — in which it may be in our interest to reason from propositions that are not true. We are disposed to rely on our beliefs, by contrast, in an open-ended range of deliberations, including, crucially, ones where we want to take only truths as premises. I shall call these latter deliberations *truth-critical with respect to premises*, or TCP for short, and I propose that it is a necessary condition for consciously believing a

[11] What follows draws on Frankish 2004, Ch.5, to which the reader is referred for extended discussion and responses to objections.

proposition that one be disposed to rely on it as a premise in relevant TCP deliberations. (Or, more precisely, in *some* relevant TCP deliberations. One can believe a proposition without being prepared to rely on its truth in all circumstances, no matter what is at stake; see Frankish 2004, pp. 134–5.) This is, I think, close to a conceptual truth — at least for conscious belief. It is not a contingent fact that we are prepared to rely on our beliefs, but not our acceptances and hypotheses, in TCP deliberations. The disposition to rely on a proposition in such deliberations is part of what makes it an object of belief, rather than of acceptance or hypothesis. (It is worth stressing that TCP deliberations are ones where we are concerned for the truth of our *premises*, rather than — or as well as — that of our conclusions. There are many contexts where truth is our goal, but where we are content to use premises we know or suspect to be false. Think, for example, of the role of theoretical fictions and thought experiments in scientific reasoning. Although these are employed with the aim of generating true beliefs, they are not themselves objects of belief, since we would not be prepared to rely on them in TCP deliberations. The attitude involved is more like the professional belief of the lawyer.)

Now I shall assume that we can be disposed to rely on a proposition in TCP deliberations even if our motives for doing so are pragmatic and we have no reason to think the proposition true. That is, we can have beliefs that are deviant and unsupported. But suppose we *recognize* that we have this disposition with respect to a particular proposition? Will we continue to rely on the proposition in TCP deliberations? Well, if rational, we should not be *willing* to do so. TCP deliberations are ones where we want to be guided only by true propositions. To be willing to be guided by false ones would be irrational, and not just epistemically but practically. No matter how useful it would be for me to act as if I believe that my boss's jokes are funny, it could not be in my interest to rely on that proposition in deliberations where I want to take only truths as premises unless it *is* true. Of course, pragmatic motives may influence *which* deliberations I treat as TCP — perhaps determining that I exclude those concerning my boss's sense of humour. But they will not influence whether or not it is in my interest to rely on a particular proposition in those deliberations I *do* treat as TCP. In those, by definition, truth is what matters most to me. Thus, unless we have some evidence for the truth of a given proposition (more at least than we have for the truth of its negation), we shall be unwilling to take it as a premise in TCP deliberations — unwilling, that is, to believe it. And if we find ourselves disposed to rely on a proposition in TCP deliberations for purely pragmatic reasons and without any grounds for thinking it true,

then we shall want to suppress the disposition — that is, to stop believing the proposition.

And that, I think, is exactly what we shall do, at least when the belief in question is conscious. Conscious reasoning is to some degree under our personal control, and if we are unwilling to rely on a particular premise in TCP deliberations, then we can refrain from doing so. (We might, of course, continue to rely on it in other, non-TCP deliberations, but we shall then reclassify it as something other than a belief — a state of acceptance or hypothesis, say.) The upshot is that RWP holds: if we identify one of our beliefs as unsupported and deviant, then we shall repudiate it and cease to believe the content in question.

Now the considerations just outlined might seem to offer a more direct argument against strong voluntarism. If it is practically rational to possess the belief that *p* only if one has reason to think that *p* is true, then, one might think, it will be practically rational to *form* that belief only if one has reason to think that *p* is true. So it will be practically irrational to form beliefs without reason to think them true, and the impossibility of believing at will reflects the constraints of practical rationality.[12] This is too swift, however. (Note that, if sound, the argument would tell equally against the possibility of actively forming unsupported beliefs by indirect means, thus violating the second constraint set out earlier.) In general, one might want to adjust one's attitudes in such a way that after the adjustment one will regard it as rational to follow a course of action that one does not currently regard as rational. And, similarly, one might judge that the practical advantages of having attitudes that dispose one to rely on a certain false proposition in TCP deliberations would outweigh the risks involved, and thereupon decide to take steps to acquire such attitudes. What this does emphasize, however, is that forming an unsupported belief would involve adjustments to one's background attitudes — adjustments that cannot be brought about directly, for the reasons discussed earlier.

4. Weak voluntarism

I return now to the defence of direct activism. I suggested that there was a prima facie case for thinking that direct activism entails weak voluntarism — the view that it is possible to form beliefs directly and for pragmatic reasons — and I now want to argue that the latter position is coherent and defensible. Note that my aim

[12] Compare Paul Noordhof's claim (2001) that when we consciously consider whether or not to believe something, the norm of truth manifests itself as a *practical* norm.

is not to show that weak voluntarism is true, or that direct activism does entail it, but merely to establish that weak voluntarism is not a priori false and that direct activism is not fatally compromised if it entails it. There is no space here for a full-scale discussion, but I shall make some basic points and address some important objections. I shall also consider some objections to direct activism itself.

The first task is to show that the argument against strong voluntarism does not carry over to the weak form. This is straightforward. If we form a mental state directly and for pragmatic reasons, then we shall typically be aware that it is deviant, but that is not incompatible with our regarding it as a belief, provided we do not also believe that it is unsupported. RWP is thus no barrier to pragmatically motivated belief formation, provided one has epistemic support for the belief to be formed. Similar considerations apply to most other anti-voluntarist arguments in the literature (setting aside the question of their soundness). Typically, they seek to establish that there would be some incoherence involved in thinking of a state as a belief if we knew that its formation had not been regulated by epistemic considerations. And weak voluntarists are not committed to denying this, since they hold that acts of endorsement are dependent for success on the presence of relevant epistemic support. So there is no inference from the falsity of strong voluntarism to the falsity of weak voluntarism or of direct activism. In practice, however, the theses are rarely distinguished, and it is not uncommon to find a writer concluding from arguments of this kind that belief formation is essentially passive.

This assumes, of course, that it is coherent to suppose that possession of epistemic support for a proposition is an enabling condition for the act of endorsing it. And, as I noted earlier, this claim needs defence. If acts of endorsement need not be epistemically motivated, why should epistemic support be necessary for their success? Reflection on RWP and the Control Principle supplies the answer. As I argued in the previous section, it is a consequence of these principles that if we believe we lack epistemic support for a proposition, then we are very unlikely to succeed in endorsing it and cannot form an intention to do so. If we believe we have such support, however, the situation will be different. There will then be no barrier to success, and we shall be able to form an intention to endorse the proposition. (Note that the higher-order belief need not itself be formed actively, through a separate act of endorsement; there is no threat of a regress here.) And since, given a typical level of self-knowledge, the belief that one possesses epis-

temic support for a proposition will normally be generated whenever one *does* possess such support, prior possession of epistemic support for a proposition will enable the formation of an intention to endorse it. That is, possession of reasons to think a proposition true will be an enabling condition for the act of endorsing it, regardless of one's reasons for *wanting* to endorse it. I conclude that we can make good sense of the idea that possession of relevant epistemic support is an enabling condition for an act of endorsement, and can, therefore, consistently embrace the weak form of voluntarism while rejecting the strong one.

What about cases where one neither believes nor disbelieves that one has epistemic support for a proposition? In order to endorse a proposition, is it necessary to believe that one does have epistemic support for it, or is it sufficient not to believe one does not? The issue is not clear. RWP presents a direct barrier to endorsement only in cases where one believes oneself to lack epistemic support for the target proposition, but it is hard to see how one could form an intention to endorse a proposition without raising the question of whether one has epistemic support for it, and, given normal self-awareness, this will typically prompt the formation of a definite view on the matter. In what follows I shall set aside this complication and assume that agents contemplating acts of endorsement are always aware of whether or not they possess relevant epistemic support.

Let us turn now to some objections to weak voluntarism. First, it may be objected that on this view acts of endorsement will be redundant. Although the lack of any reason to think a proposition true may prevent our endorsing it, the mere possession of such reasons will not necessarily enable us to do so. We shall need to regard the reasons as *sufficient* for belief. But in forming the belief that we have sufficient reason to believe a proposition, we shall come to believe the proposition itself; the higher-order belief will automatically generate the first-order one. There will thus be no room for a further act of pragmatically motivated endorsement.[13]

Now, it is important to note that this objection presupposes a strong claim about the relation between the higher-order beliefs and first-order beliefs in question. The claim must be that forming the belief that one has sufficient reason to believe a proposition, *p*, *constitutively involves* forming the belief that *p* — not just

[13] Note that this objection applies equally to non-voluntarist versions of direct activism. On such views, acts of belief formation are motivated in part by higher-order beliefs of the kind described, and will be redundant if such beliefs automatically yield the corresponding first-order ones. See Walker 1996, pp. 113–6.

that the former event typically prompts the latter. The weak voluntarist can accept the latter claim, insisting only that the formation of the first-order belief is — in some cases, at least — a distinct act, which can in principle be pragmatically motivated. And there do seem to be exceptions to the constitutive claim. We sometimes fall into a sort of theoretical akrasia, judging that we ought to believe something but failing to do so, perhaps for emotional reasons. This may not, it is true, be a knock-down response; the possibility of theoretical akrasia is disputed (Adler 2002; Owens 2002), and it is certainly a pathological condition. Fortunately, however, there is another, more conciliatory line of reply open to the weak voluntarist. Distinguish two higher-order beliefs: the belief that the evidence is such that it would be irrational not to believe that *p*, and the belief that the evidence is such that it would not be irrational to believe that *p* (at the very least, that *p* is more probable than not-*p*). Perhaps we cannot acquire the former belief without coming to believe that *p*; for the sake of argument let us concede the point. But it is certainly possible to acquire the latter belief without believing that *p*. One might simply suspend judgement pending further evidence. And that is all the weak voluntarist requires. Provided we think *p* is a better candidate for truth than not-*p*, it will not be irrational to rely on *p* in relevant TCP deliberations (or at least in non-momentous ones), and we shall be able to regard it as an object of belief.

To sum up: there is a distinction between reasons that are sufficient to permit belief and reasons that are sufficient to compel it. There are propositions for which we have sufficient reason in the former sense but not in the latter, and it is in relation to such propositions, the weak voluntarist will maintain, that active belief formation can be practised. The objector conflates the two notions of sufficiency and thereby threatens to beg the question. These considerations also harmonize well with the weak voluntarist's claim that belief formation can be pragmatically motivated. For it may require pragmatic motives, or at least ones related to the pragmatics of inquiry, to induce us to come off the fence and make a clear doxastic commitment. Of course, if strong voluntarism is false, pragmatic considerations cannot determine *which side* of the fence we come down on; that will be determined by the evidence available to us. But they may determine *that* we come off the fence at all — that we form a belief on some matter rather than withholding judgement. (On the role of practical desire in belief formation, see Yee 2002.)

A second objection turns on facts about justification. If belief formation can be pragmatically motivated, then it should be possible to justify belief possession

on pragmatic grounds. But it is not. My belief that my boss's jokes are funny is not justified by the fact that it will help me keep my job, even if it serves that end. So belief formation cannot be pragmatically motivated. Now at first sight it might seem that this objection simply equivocates on the norms in relation to which beliefs can be justified. In relation to pragmatic norms, I might well be justified in possessing a belief in my boss's humorousness; it is only in relation to epistemic ones that I would not be. But the challenge cannot be dismissed so easily; the weak voluntarist still has to explain why we do not think it *appropriate* to justify belief possession in pragmatic terms. From our present perspective, however, there is a ready answer to this. As we saw, if believing a proposition involves being disposed to rely on it in TCP deliberations, then no matter how useful it might be to possess a certain belief, it will be practically irrational to do so unless we regard the belief as licensed by epistemic norms. Thus, reference to the practical advantages of possessing a given belief will never be sufficient to justify its possession. Moreover, since most of us regard true beliefs as desirable for their own sake, showing that a belief is epistemically justified typically *will* be sufficient to justify its possession.

I turn finally to two objections to direct activism itself, both of which develop the other reason for rejecting the doctrine mentioned at the outset — that belief is not the sort of state that can be actively formed. Neither of the objections is fatal, but they will force us to adopt a more specific view of the nature of acts of endorsement. The first objection, sketched by Jonathan Bennett, targets the claim that belief formation can be immediate, like arm raising (Bennett 1990). Belief, Bennett points out, is a dispositional state. And how could we immediately bring about a change in our dispositions? One can create a dispositional state only by creating some categorical state on which it supervenes. Hence there is no such action as *just* forming a belief; the formation of a belief must proceed by the intermediate production of some specific categorical state.

Now, as it stands, this argument is flawed in a number of ways, as Bennett himself points out.[14] But there is some plausibility to the idea that we cannot alter our dispositions just like that, simply by willing it. I suggested earlier that believing a proposition involves being disposed to trust it in TCP deliberations, and

[14] One worry is that there seems to be a similar supervenience pattern with arm raising; my arm rising now supervenes on its rising now *in some determinate manner*. So I cannot *just* raise my arm; the raising of my arm must proceed via the intermediate production of some more determinate arm-raising.

could we really make it the case that we had such a disposition, straight off, without doing anything else? I suspect not (though a lot more work would be required to make the case solid). So I do not propose to challenge Bennett's conclusion. Instead, I want to show that it is not incompatible with direct activism. In order to see this, it will be necessary to say more about what sort of state an actively formed belief might be. I can only give the briefest indication of the account I favour, but it will be enough for present purposes. (For the full story, see Frankish 2004.) Let me stress, too, that this account is intended to apply only to conscious beliefs and only to one particular variety of them; it is obvious that many beliefs are not constituted in the way described.

The account turns on the idea that we have a measure of direct control over our conscious reasoning — that we can deliberately initiate and sustain trains of reasoning and can choose which inferential procedures to use and which propositions to take as inputs to them. If that is right, then we shall be able to adopt certain *policies* of reasoning — policies of using, or not using, certain propositions as premises in certain contexts. And actively forming a belief, I suggest, involves resolving upon just such a policy. More precisely, I suggest that endorsing the content *p* involves resolving upon a policy of using *p* as a premise in an open-ended range of deliberations, including TCP ones. This suggestion needs a lot of filling out, of course, but suppose the core idea is right. Then we have an answer to Bennett's worry. For it is easy to see how resolving on a policy would alter one's dispositions. Adopting a policy makes one disposed to adhere to it — by focusing one's attention on the policy and the reasons for adhering to it, by establishing the fulfilment of the policy as a settled goal which takes priority over more transient ones, and by providing an additional motive for performing the actions it dictates.

Now in proposing this account of active belief formation I have in effect conceded Bennett's conclusion. We do not form beliefs immediately, but only by way of some other, more basic action: adopting a premising policy. And this concession might seem incompatible with direct activism. The incompatibility is only apparent, however. For direct activism specifies that endorsement is a *causally* basic act. And although on the proposed view it is a non-basic act, the indirection involved is not causal. On this view, one forms a belief by adopting a premising policy, but adopting the policy does not *cause* one to form the belief. Rather, adopting the policy *is* forming the belief. The indirection is intentional or teleological, not causal (Hornsby 1980).

The account just sketched can also help us to deal with a second objection to direct activism, this time due to Brian O'Shaughnessy (1980, pp. 26–7). Simplified somewhat, the argument runs as follows. Believing is a state, not an event. And when we actively bring about the existence of a state, we do so by bringing about some event which is the state's onset. But bringing about the onset of a state is typically the culmination of an active *process*: the onset of the state of *touching* is the culmination of the activity of *reaching out*, the onset of the state of *being seated* is the culmination of the activity of *sitting down*, and so on. And there does not seem to be any comparable activity of which the onset of *believing* might be the culmination. So an act of belief formation, were it possible, would be an act which is not the culmination of an activity; it would be a momentary act which brings about a simultaneous and momentary event. And, O'Shaughnessy suggests, we have no precedents for such an act.

I think we can concede all of this except the last bit. For there are precedents for such acts. Consider performatives. Suppose you were unfamiliar with performative utterances. Then if you were told that members of an alien community could perform actions that would instantly bring it about that a meeting was closed, or that a ship had a certain name, or that two people were man and wife, then you might naturally fall into a similar line of thought to that outlined above. How could there be a momentary act which brought about the simultaneous and momentary onset of a state of closure, or naming, or obligation? What could be the activities of which these events were the culmination? The mystery would be dispelled, of course, by the discovery that these actions were not intentionally basic but constituted by other, more fundamental activities — that *naming a ship*, for example, was the culmination of the process of *saying certain words with certain intentions in a certain context*. And, I propose, something similar might go for endorsement. I have suggested that forming a conscious belief involves adopting a premising policy. And such an action is, arguably, a performative one. Adopting a public policy typically involves *stating* that one adopts it with the intention of thereby doing so. And adopting a premising policy might involve an internalized version of such an action — saying to oneself 'I endorse *p*', or something similar, with the intention of thereby committing oneself to a policy of premising that *p*. If so, then the activity of which the onset of believing is the culmination would be that of making some private mental utterance.

None of the objections considered is compelling, then. And given the possibility just sketched, I think it is unlikely that any a priori argument against weak

voluntarism will be successful. Premising policies can be actively adopted for pragmatic reasons; so if it is coherent to suppose that beliefs can take the form of premising policies, then it must be coherent to suppose that beliefs can be formed in the same way.

5. Conclusion

The aim of this paper has been to open a conceptual space — to establish direct activism, in a weakly voluntarist form, as a coherent and defensible position. In the course of it I have also hinted at a substantive story about actively formed belief — a story that identifies such beliefs with premising policies. There are, I believe, independent reasons for thinking that this story is true and therefore that direct activism is too, but the fact that it is consistent is enough for present purposes. If you have not yet endorsed the proposition that direct activism is a coherent and defensible position, then I urge you to do so now.[15]

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